

LHUM400: Liberal Humanities

Professional Development for Creative Careers / Summer 2026 Syllabus

Term	Summer 2026 (12-week compressed format)
Credits	3 credit hours
Prerequisites	Open enrollment
Format	In-person with digital portfolio components
Instructor	Prof. Kramer Gibson
Office	7 Haviland, Room 326
Email	ggibson1@berklee.edu
Office hours	Tuesdays 11:00 AM - 1:00 PM, or by appointment

About the Professor



Prof. Kramer Gibson is a music educator, ESL instructor, and lifelong language nut. He earned a Bachelor of Arts in Professional Music from Berklee (after a detour through chemistry and economics at Miami University in Ohio) and a Master of Education in curriculum design. His teaching spans three formative settings: twelve years of K-8 general music in the Boston Public Schools, a year living and teaching music in Qingdao, China, and now his third year as a college-level ESL instructor at Berklee.

Outside the classroom he plays funk drums and sings as a solo looping artist on an RC-505, as well as drums and bass in rock, funk, and folk bands. He has studied Spanish and Portuguese for fifteen years, French for ten, Japanese for eight, and Mandarin for five. He lives in Brighton, Massachusetts, near the Charles River, with his wife and their two Siberian cats, Luci and Mixolydian.

Course Description

LHUM400 bridges the gap between academic learning and professional readiness, preparing creative professionals for successful careers in the modern music industry and beyond. Through a carefully sequenced blend of self-reflection, skill development, and strategic planning, students develop the professional communication abilities, business acumen, and ethical framework necessary for independent creative careers.

The course combines traditional liberal arts critical thinking with practical professional development, emphasizing the unique challenges and opportunities facing creative professionals in today's economy. Students build a comprehensive professional portfolio while developing the habits, relationships, and strategic thinking essential for long-term career success.

Learning Outcomes

Upon successful completion of LHUM400, students will be able to:

Professional Communication

- Create polished professional documents including resumes, cover letters, and artist statements
- Communicate effectively with industry professionals, clients, and collaborators
- Present a clear, compelling professional identity across multiple platforms

Digital Professional Presence

- Design and maintain a professional website portfolio
- Navigate social media strategically for networking and brand development
- Use digital tools for project management, financial planning, and client communication

Career Development & Strategic Planning

- Articulate clear professional goals with actionable implementation strategies
- Research and evaluate diverse career pathways in creative industries
- Build and maintain professional networks through authentic relationship development

Business & Financial Literacy

- Create and maintain personal and project budgets using analytical tools
- Understand pricing strategies and client relationship management for freelance work
- Make strategic decisions using data analysis and systematic evaluation processes

Professional Ethics & Leadership

- Apply values-based decision-making frameworks to career choices
- Demonstrate resilience and growth mindset in response to professional challenges
- Contribute to creative communities through mentorship and leadership

Critical Thinking & Integration

- Synthesize diverse learning experiences into comprehensive career planning
- Analyze industry trends and adapt professional strategies accordingly
- Connect liberal arts education to practical professional applications

Course Structure

The summer compression sequences five developmental phases across twelve weeks: (1) Foundation & Self-Awareness, (2) Professional Communication Tools, (3) Professional Engagement & Research, (4) Practical Business Skills, and (5) Professional Portfolio Integration. Each week pairs a discussion prompt with applied assignment work, building toward a capstone cluster of portfolio, essay, and final presentation.

Major Assignments

Fifteen numbered assignments plus a Week 1 Readiness Audit and a final presentation, organized into five thematic phases that build toward a capstone cluster (Portfolio, Final Essay, Final Presentation). Sixteen weekly discussion prompts run alongside the assignment sequence.

#	Title	Phase
1	Class Introduction	Foundation
2	Artist Statement Draft	Foundation
3	Resume Draft 1	Foundation
4	Fan Website Practice	Communication
5	Professional Habits Goals	Communication
6	Cover Letter Practice 1	Communication
7	Cover Letter Practice 2	Communication
8	Updated Resume	Communication
9	Professional Interview Essay	Engagement
10	Berklee Alumni Reflection	Engagement
11	Decision-Making Spreadsheet	Business
12	Budget Spreadsheet	Business
13	Private Client Work (3 artifacts + approval gate)	Business
14	Website Portfolio	Capstone
15	Final Essay: Career Path	Capstone
—	Final Presentation (brief, informal portfolio walk-through)	Capstone

Assessment & Grading

The course uses a 1000-point total across six categories. Every assignment's weight is readable as a percentage at a glance (50 pts = 5%).

Category	Points	Weight
Foundation & Self-Awareness	140	14%
Professional Communication	200	20%
Engagement & Research	100	10%
Business Skills	180	18%
Capstone (Portfolio + Final Essay + Final Presentation)	220	22%

Category	Points	Weight
Discussions (16 prompts x 10 pts)	160	16%
Total	1000	100%

Point Values by Item

Foundation & Self-Awareness (140 pts / 14%)

Item	Pts	Notes
Week 1 Readiness Audit	20	Completion only; baseline for Week 12 delta
Asg 1 Class Introduction	20	Low-stakes, community building
Asg 2 Artist Statement Draft	40	First substantive writing piece
Asg 3 Resume Draft 1	60	First major professional document
Subtotal	140	

Professional Communication (200 pts / 20%)

Item	Pts	Notes
Asg 4 Fan Website Practice	30	Skill-building exercise, low stakes
Asg 5 Professional Habits Goals	30	Planning document, completion-heavy
Asg 6 Cover Letter Practice 1	40	Emergency-job scenario
Asg 7 Cover Letter Practice 2	50	Real job application, higher stakes
Asg 8 Updated Resume	50	Iteration of Asg 3; mid-semester portfolio review point
Subtotal	200	

Engagement & Research (100 pts / 10%)

Item	Pts	Notes
Asg 9 Professional Interview Essay	60	Real-world contact required
Asg 10 Berklee Alumni Reflection	40	Web research + reflection
Subtotal	100	

Business Skills (180 pts / 18%)

Item	Pts	Notes
Asg 11 Decision-Making Spreadsheet	40	Analytical tool-building
Asg 12 Budget Spreadsheet	40	Financial planning tool
Asg 13 Private Client Work	100	Three artifacts plus gated approval
Subtotal	180	

Capstone (220 pts / 22%)

Item	Pts	Notes
Asg 14 Website Portfolio	110	Public-facing professional surface; semester-long build
Asg 15 Final Essay: Career Path	70	Strategic synthesis writing
Final Presentation	40	Brief, informal portfolio walk-through
Subtotal	220	

Discussions (160 pts / 16%)

Item	Pts	Notes
16 Discussions x 10 pts each	160	Rubric: 6 pts initial post, 4 pts peer reply
Subtotal	160	

Grading Scale

Letter	Percent	Points (of 1000)
A	93-100	930-1000
A-	90-92	900-929

Letter	Percent	Points (of 1000)
B+	87-89	870-899
B	83-86	830-869
B-	80-82	800-829
C+	77-79	770-799
C	73-76	730-769
Below C	below 73	below 730

Course Policies

Attendance Policy

Regular attendance is essential for this discussion-based course. The summer policy is designed to give students real flexibility while protecting the integrity of the course.

Absences	Consequence
0-3	No penalty, for any reason. No documentation required, no explanation needed.
4-5	10% reduction in final course grade.
6 or more	Failure of the course.

Students are expected to attend all class sessions punctually and prepared for discussion, participate actively, and complete reading and preparation assignments before class. When you miss class, you are responsible for catching up on missed material and arranging any needed makeup work.

Late Work Policy

Professional development requires meeting deadlines consistently. Late assignments are penalized at **10% per day** for each day past the deadline. Extensions may be granted for documented emergencies or health issues when requested in advance.

Academic Integrity

All work submitted must be original and completed individually unless collaboration is specifically assigned. Students are expected to cite all sources appropriately, avoid plagiarism in all written assignments and presentations, maintain confidentiality regarding peer work shared in class, and uphold professional standards of honesty and integrity.

Technology & Professional Standards

Students are expected to maintain professional email communication, submit assignments in the specified digital formats with correct file naming, and use technology responsibly during class. The course expects professional communication in all interactions, respect for diverse perspectives, constructive feedback delivery, and ethical behavior in all course activities and professional networking.

Weekly Schedule

Twelve-week compressed summer pacing. Each week introduces or completes assignments from one of the five developmental phases.

Wk	Theme	Discussion	Assignment Activity
1	Professional Identity Foundation	Class Introduction discussion; Week 1 Readiness Audit	Asg 1 (Class Introduction), Asg 2 (Artist Statement Draft) introduced
2	Self-Awareness & Goal Setting	Professional Habits Goals discussion	Asg 1 due; Asg 3 (Resume Draft 1) and Asg 5 (Professional Habits Goals) introduced
3	Organization & Digital Foundations	Organization Systems discussion	Asg 2 due; Asg 4 (Fan Website Practice) introduced
4	Professional Communication I	Cover Letter Emergency Job discussion	Asg 3 and Asg 5 due; Asg 6 (Cover Letter Practice 1) introduced
5	Digital Skills & Cover Letter Iteration	Soft Skills Reflection discussion; Cover Letter Real Job discussion	Asg 4 due; Asg 6 due; Asg 7 (Cover Letter Practice 2) introduced
6	Professional Identity Integration	Other Berklee Alumni Reflection discussion; Goal Setting Evidence discussion	Asg 7 due; Asg 8 (Updated Resume) and Asg 10 (Berklee Alumni Reflection) introduced

Wk	Theme	Discussion	Assignment Activity
7	Strategic Networking & Career Research	Career Moves / New City Networking discussion	Asg 8 due (mid-semester portfolio review); Asg 9 (Professional Interview Essay) introduced
8	Digital Professional Presence	Social Media Strategy discussion	Asg 10 due; Asg 11 (Decision-Making Spreadsheet) and Asg 14 (Website Portfolio) introduced
9	Data Analysis & Habits Check-In	Professional Habits Check-In discussion; Career Center Resources discussion	Asg 9 due; Asg 11 due; Asg 12 (Budget Spreadsheet) introduced
10	Business Skills & Client Relations	Values & Decision Making discussion	Asg 12 due; Asg 13 (Private Client Work) introduced; Asg 15 (Final Essay) introduced
11	Resilience & Leadership	Learning from Failure discussion; Mentorship & Leadership discussion	Asg 13 due; Asg 14 due
12	Creative Integrity & Future Planning	Creative Integrity vs Commercial Success discussion	Asg 15 due; Final Presentations; Week 12 Readiness Audit re-take

Note: the weekly schedule is a living plan and may be adjusted based on class needs and pacing. Students will be notified promptly of any significant changes.

Required Materials & Resources

Technology: reliable internet, a computer that can run spreadsheets and website-creation tools, a professional email account, and video-calling capability for interviews.

Software: spreadsheet software (Excel, Google Sheets, or equivalent); a website builder (WordPress, Wix, Squarespace, or similar); PDF creation tools; and basic video recording capability. Free options are sufficient throughout.

Research resources: Berklee Career Manager (primary job-market resource), the Other Berklee Alumni Website (www.otherberklealumni.com), industry professional-association sites, and LinkedIn Learning.

Support Resources

Berklee resources available to you throughout the course: Career Services (resume review, interview prep, job search), the Writing Center, Academic Advisors, Counseling Services, the IT Help Desk, the Alumni Network, and faculty office hours.

This syllabus is a living document subject to modification based on class needs, institutional requirements, and industry developments. Students will be notified promptly of any significant changes.

Prof. Kramer Gibson - Berklee College of Music